

PHISHING AWARENESS TRAINING

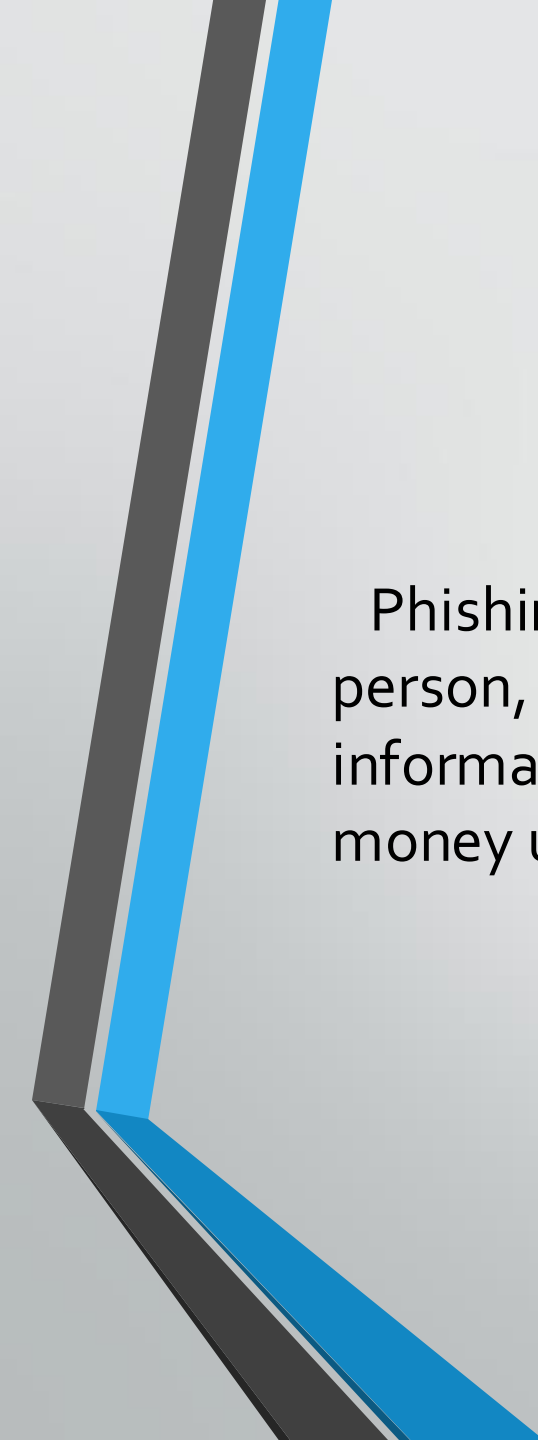
Understanding Phishing Attacks, Social Engineering & How to Stay Safe

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Cybersecurity Internship by code alpha – Task 2

TOPICS COVERD

- Recognizing phishing emails
- Identifying fake websites
- Social engineering tactics
- Best practices for staying safe
- Real world phishing examples
- Keypoint takeaway
- Interactive quiz
- Conclusion



What is Phishing ?

Phishing is a type of cyberattack where an attacker pretends to be trusted person, company, or organization to trick someone into giving away information, clicking a malicious link, opening an attachment, or sending money under false pretense

What does an attackers want ?

- Passwords
 - Bank or payment information
 - Personal information
 - Company information
 - Access to an account
 - Money
-
- EXAMPLE: "Your bank account will be blocked today. Click here to verify your account."
 - KEYPOINT : The message may look real, but the attacker is trying to make the victim panic and act without thinking.

How does a phishing attack works ?

A phishing attacks usually follows these steps :

- Create a believable message : The attacker pretends to be someone you trust
- Create urgency of fear : They may say your account will be closed or you must act immediately.
- Give you something to click or open : A link , Attachement, QR code, or phone number to text or call.
- The victim takes the action : They click, log in, download something, or send information.
- The attacker gets what they wanted : Credentials, Money, Information, or Access.

KEY POINT :

Attackers often attack the person before they attack the computer.

Types of phishing

- Email phishing : Fake emails designed to trick users.
- Spear phishing : A targeted phishing attack aimed at a specific person or organization.
- Whaling : spear phishing aimed at important people such as executives or company leaders.
- Smishing : Phishing through SMS or messaging apps.
- Vishing : Phishing through voice calls.
- Business Email Compromise (BEC) : Attackers impersonate executives, employees, or business partners to trick organizations into sending money or sensitive information.

How to Recognize a phishing Emails

Look for these warning signs :

- Unknown or suspicious sender
- Urgent language : "ACT NOW"
- Requests for passwords or sensitive information
- Unexpected attachments : " SUSPICIOUS LINKS"
- Spelling or grammar mistakes
- Unexpected payment requests
- The sender's address doesn't match the organization

REMEMBER THIS

STOP – CHECK – VERIFY – THEN ACT

Check the Sender

Attackers often create email addresses that look almost legitimate.

Examples :

Legitimate email : support@microsoft.com

Suspicious email : support@microsoft-security-help.com

The second address may look convincing, but it is not automatically a Microsoft address.

What to check :

Look carefully at the full email address.

Check the domain.

Be careful with spelling changes.

Check the Reply-To address.

Don't trust an email just because the display name looks familiar.

KEY POINT

A familiar name does not always mean a familiar sender

How to Recognize a Fake Website

Before entering your password or personal information ;

- Check the website address

Look carefully at the actual domain.

- For example :

 - Login.microsoftonline.com

Is different from:

 - Login.microsoftonline.com.example-site.com

The second one is actually under example-site.com

Also check :

- Unexpected redirects links

- Strange spelling

- Unusual domain names

- Unexpected login pages

- Requests for sensitive information

- Poor or unusual website design

Social Engineering

Social engineering is the use of psychological manipulation to trick people into doing something they normally wouldn't do. Instead of attacking the computer directly, the attacker would trick, threaten, or manipulate the victim.

COMMON TACTICS THEY USE :

- Fear : "Your account has been compromised"
- Urgency : "You have 10 minutes to respond."
- Authority : "This is your CEO. Send the payment now."
- Curiosity : "You have won a prize."
- Trust : "pretending to be someone you know."
- Secrecy : "Don't tell anyone about this request."

Real World Examples

Fake Microsoft Email Alert

Subject : Your Microsoft account will be suspended !

Click this link to avoid your account been suspended! <https://resetexamplespassword.com>

The email tells the user that their account has a security problem and asks them to click a button to verify their account.

Warning signs:

- Creates fear
- Creates urgency
- Requests a login
- Uses a suspicious sender/domain
- Sends the user to an unexpected website

What should you do ?

- Don't click the link.
- Don't enter your password.
- Open the organization's official website yourself.
- Verify the alert through a trusted channel.

Real world example

Fake Vendor Payment

“Our bank account has changed. Please send today’s payment to our new account immediately.” 00456735 examples ng limited account

Warning Signs :

- Banking information suddenly changed
- Urgent request
- Payment involved
- Request may come from a compromised or fake account

Safe response:

Don’t simply reply to the email.

Contact the vendor using a trusted phone number already on file. Confirm the change independently.

Key Point

Never verify a suspicious request using the same communication channel that made the request.

Best practices to avoid phishing

- STOP AND THINK : Don't act immediately because a message is urgent.
- CHECK LINKS : Look at where a link actually leads before opening it.
- CHECK THE SENDER : Look carefully at the complete email address.
- USE MFA: Multi-factor authentication provides another layer of protection.
- BE CAREFUL WITH ATTACHMENTS LINKS: Don't open unexpected files
- VERIFY REQUESTS: Especially requests involving money, passwords, MFA codes, Account changes, Sensitive information
- REPORT PHISHING: Tell your IT/security team or use your organization's reporting process

What should you do if you clicked a phishing link?

- Don't panic , Don't hide it, Act quickly.
- Stop interacting with the suspicious website/message.
- Report the incident to your IT/security team.
- If you enter a password, change it through the legitimate website.
- If the same password is used elsewhere, change it there too.
- Follow your organization's incident-response instructions
- Watch out for unusual account activity.

KEY POINT

Reporting quickly can help reduce the damage.

Interactive Quiz

Question 1

You receive an email saying: "Your account will be permanently deleted in 15 minutes. Click here now!"

What should you do?

- A. Click immediately
- B. Forward it to friends
- C. Verify through an official channel
- D. Enter your password

ANSWER : ?

Question 2

Your manager suddenly emails asking you to send money to a new bank account . What should you do ?

- A. Send it immediately
- B. Independently verify the request
- C. Reply asking for their password
- D. Ignore every business emails

ANSWER : ?

Phishing identification challenge

Which signs makes this message suspicious?

From: security@microsoft-account-help.example

Subject : URGENT! Your account will be deleted!

"You must verify your account within 10 minutes . Click the link below and enter your password."
<https://.resetexamplespassword.com>

Find the red flags

- Suspicious sender
- Urgent deadline
- Threat of account deletion
- Request for passwords
- Suspicious link
- Pressure to act without verification

YOUR TASK : Would you click it ? Why or why not?

Key takeaways

Remember these 6 things :

- Stop : Don't rush because a message is urgent.
- Check : Check the sender, link, attachment, and request.
- Verify : Confirm suspicious requests through a trusted channel.
- Protect : Use a strong passwords and MFA.
- Report : Report suspicious messages to the appropriate security/IT team.
- Think : Remember that attackers often use human emotions to manipulate

Conclusion

Phishing Awareness is not only a technical problem. It is also a human and social engineering problem.

By learning to :

- Recognize suspicious messages
- Check website addresses
- Question urgent requests
- Verify information independently
- Protect accounts with MFA
- Report suspicious activity

We can greatly reduce the risk of becoming a phishing victim.

Cybersecurity starts with awareness.